

Everything is a Remix

PHASE 1: The Evolution of Ideas

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Everything we see has evolved from something that came before it. Every book, every song, every movie, every app, every design, and every idea. Nothing is truly original.

PHASE 2: The Romantic Movie Formula

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Take romantic movies, they all revolve around the same simple premise. The hero meets the female lead, and we feel chemistry between them. Then the story builds on that foundation, getting us heavily invested in their love story. Just when we're rooting for them to get together, the story takes a sharp turn. They grow apart or something terrible happens. Now we're heartbroken but even more invested in their relationship. We follow their journey through struggles, thinking, "I wish they'd get back together somehow." By the end, we usually get that reunion. Sometimes we don't, and it's even more romantic because of the sacrifices they made. But this isn't new. It's been happening since the beginning of time. Look at the oldest book or movie in this genre, and you'll find the same story.

PHASE 3: Originality vs. Usability in Design

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] My point is, if movies aren't even original, what about apps and websites? Even if you consider design a form of art, it can't be at the level of movies. In design, originality isn't the main goal. Usability is. Originality comes in small doses. A color scheme, a typography choice, a micro-interaction, the way images load. Those little touches are where you make it yours. You can't sit around trying to think of something that's never been done before, because that's pretty much impossible. How can you imagine the unseen?

PHASE 4: Creativity as Remixing

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Creative people don't come up with new ideas out of thin air. Every creative idea comes from something you've seen before. Something that struck a chord, something that resonated and made an impact. We humans love reimagining things. We like to think we could do it better, put our own spin on it. We believe we could do it in a way that appeals more to us, to our generation, to people like us. After all, TikTok creators dance to the same track a million times and go viral. You can absolutely take an existing layout, interaction, or pattern and then polish it. Modernize it. Make it faster,

make it cleaner. That is creativity. Honestly, most of the products and websites we love are just better versions of something that already existed.

PHASE 5: Evolution of Design Trends

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Even design trends are cycles. Flat design took print design minimalism. Skeuomorphism copied real-world objects. Brutalism in web design borrowed from architectural brutalism. Glassmorphism isn't new. iOS 7 in 2013 made it trendy on mobile. But Windows Vista's Aero Glass from 2006 already had the translucent look. Both, of course, were inspired by real frosted glass.

PHASE 6: Evolution of UI Patterns

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] The hamburger menu icon was designed by Norm Cox for Xerox Star in 1981. It sat quietly for decades until mobile apps brought it back in the 2010s. Pull-to-refresh was created by Loren Brichter in the Tweetie app in 2009. Twitter later bought both the app and the patent before the gesture spread everywhere. Infinite scroll was invented by Aza Raskin in 2006. Social feeds like Twitter and Facebook made it mainstream a few years later. The like button wasn't born on Facebook. Vimeo added a "like" button in 2005. FriendFeed had it in 2007. And Facebook only introduced its famous thumbs-up version in 2009. What Facebook really did was take the idea and make it global. Modal windows came from desktop applications. Breadcrumb navigation came from file systems.

PHASE 7: Finding Inspiration

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] New ideas come from things already around you. You just need to look in the right places.

PHASE 8: Execution Over Originality

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Don't avoid something just because your competition has done it. Do it better. Google wasn't the first search engine. They built upon existing web crawling technology from search engines like AltaVista and Lycos, then revolutionized relevance with PageRank. An algorithm that, while inspired by academic citation principles, represented a genuinely innovative approach to ranking web pages. Facebook combined elements from Friendster's social networking concept, MySpace's customizable profiles, and traditional college directories, but executed them more effectively. Twitter mixed SMS with blogging to make micro-blogging.

PHASE 9: Evolution of Tech Products

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Uber digitized traditional taxi dispatch systems with mobile apps and GPS tracking. Lyft copied Uber's core model but positioned itself as more friendly and community-focused. Grab adapted the ride-sharing concept for Southeast Asian markets. Didi did the same for China. Bolt focused on European and African markets. Every ride-sharing app follows the same fundamental concept, with different execution and branding.

PHASE 10: Evolution of Productivity Tools

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Notion combined wikis, databases, and note-taking apps into a unified workspace. Slack transformed email-style communication into real-time, organized channels. Figma took Sketch and made it collaborative and web-based.

PHASE 11: Evolution of the iPhone

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] The iPhone's interface drew from multiple sources. The desktop metaphor of folders and icons. Touch interfaces from earlier PDAs and research prototypes. And multi-touch technology that had been developing in research labs for years. Apple nailed it by combining everything with seamless integration and elegant implementation.

PHASE 12: Evolution of Business Models

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] The App Store centralized software distribution, similar to how Linux distributions had managed packages, but with a commercial model and consumer-friendly interface. Airbnb started by renting air mattresses during a conference, but it succeeded combining several existing concepts. The personal touch of bed and breakfasts, the convenience of hotel booking systems, the peer-to-peer model pioneered by CouchSurfing, and elements of classified advertising and vacation rental agencies. The big innovation was trust. Reviews, payments, guarantees, that made staying in a stranger's home feel safe.

PHASE 13: Roots of Simple UI Patterns

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] Even the simplest UI patterns have deep roots. Tab navigation. That's just digital file folders. The same tabs you'd find on physical folders, index card systems, notebook dividers, or filing cabinets. We've been organizing information this way since libraries started using card catalogs. The digital version just made it clickable. Sidebar navigation follows the same pattern. Newspapers have used column layouts for centuries. Books have had margins for annotations forever. When desktop computers needed file browsers, Mac Finder and Windows Explorer naturally adopted sidebar layouts, just like print design had been doing for decades.

PHASE 14: Conclusion

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] We took what worked in the physical world and made it interactive. The point is, everything is a remix. Everything is built on top of what came before. You don't have to invent something from scratch. Take existing ideas and execute them better, faster, cleaner, or for a different audience. Stop trying to be original. Stop telling yourself you have to create something unique. And maybe you'll free yourself to make something good.